

AFTERSHOCKS Ahmedabad's Chandola Lake slums face a second wave of demolitions, May 20

Takeaways

- **Gujarat Police swoops down on Muslim ghettos; 6,500 detained**
- **Many let off: papers prove they are natives of UP, Bihar, Bengal, not 'illegal aliens'**
- **12,500 shanties in Chandola Talav razed, 400,000 sq. metres cleared**
- **Intelligence inputs speak of terror modules, activists hint at real estate interests**

GUJARAT

RAZING AN ILLEGAL STORM

Aftershocks of a terror attack in Kashmir are felt in the ghettos of Ahmedabad, Vadodara, Surat. Thousands displaced, land gets freed, amid a welter of charges

By **Jumana Shah**

A SECURITY SWEEP SOUNDS like a good idea after a terror outrage. One came four days after Pahalgam. Targets? Over 6,500 people alleged to be illegal Bangladeshi immigrants in faraway Ahmedabad, Vadodara and Surat. Two days after Gujarat Police swooped down for this mass detention, it joined the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC) to also demolish 12,500 shanties around Chandola Lake, one of the city's Muslim ghettos. Some 25,000 inhabitants were displaced as a total of 400,000 sq. metres was cleared. The demolition, done without notice, wasn't stayed by the Gujarat High Court on the grounds that this was government land.

A SHORT HISTORY OF SLUMS

After the 2002 post-Godhra riots, Muslims across rural Gujarat left their homes and farmland to seek safety in numbers in the city. Becoming invisible in these deep, dark urban catacombs was a survival reflex. Over the years, Ahmedabad saw Juhapura, Chandola Talav, Bombay Hotel, Citizennagar, Millatnagar, Shah-e-Alam etc. swell in open sight. Mirror images bloomed in Vadodara and Surat. Impenetrable, unlit, unserved, these attracted the most underprivileged—economic refugees *sans frontieres*. Politicians of all hues, aided by local goons, profited off their induction into the local ecosystem. No titles, no roads, no official electricity, sewerage or water. The basics were allowed to flow in. A classic house of cards. It fell, as the bullets at Pahalgam disturbed the air across India. Disquiet spread fast here. Cops barged into homes between April 24 and April 28 and made arrests. 'Illegal Bangladeshis', went the charge. More than half were let off; documents showed they were Indians from Bihar, UP, Bengal. Then the JCBs lined up before dawn at Chan-